

Games and Play SIG at CSCW: Approaching Games Research from a CSCW Perspective

Guo Freeman
guof@clemson.edu
Clemson University
Clemson, South Carolina, USA

Regan L. Mandryk
reganmandryk@uvic.ca
University of Victoria
Victoria, British Columbia, Canada

Julian Frommel
j.frommel@uu.nl
Utrecht University
Utrecht, Netherlands

Pejman Mirza-Babaei
pejman@uoit.ca
Ontario Tech University
Oshawa, Ontario, Canada

Cliff Lampe
cacl@umich.edu
University of Michigan
Ann Arbor, MI, USA

ABSTRACT

The social and collaborative side of games and play has given rise to many questions about the social dynamics of digital games and their impacts on groups, teams, communities, and societies, which are highly valuable and relevant to the CSCW community. In the history of CSCW, diverse groups of researchers, students, academics, practitioners, and developers have contributed to introducing and promoting games and play research, either through studying game-play itself or leveraging games and play as a valuable context to study other core CSCW concepts/questions. Despite the shared research interests in games and play, we understand that these groups of researchers may often lack a dedicated opportunity to get together at CSCW to connect, network, and learn from each other's various research efforts and perspectives. We also recognize that there are currently many members of the larger CSCW community whose research and practice intersects with games and play. The main goal of this SIG is to help both games and play researchers at CSCW and CSCW researchers who are interested in knowing more about games and play research connect with each other and further build a sense of community. Together, we aim to strengthen ties between games and play research and other areas of research within CSCW and explore how games research and CSCW can benefit from each other.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → **Interaction devices**; • **Information systems** → **Massively multiplayer online games**; • **Applied computing** → **Computer games**; • **Software and its engineering** → **Interactive games**.

KEYWORDS

games and play, social gaming, collaborative gaming, esports, virtual communities

ACM Reference Format:

Guo Freeman, Regan L. Mandryk, Julian Frommel, Pejman Mirza-Babaei, and Cliff Lampe. 2024. Games and Play SIG at CSCW: Approaching Games Research from a CSCW Perspective. In *Companion of the 2024 Computer-Supported Cooperative Work and Social Computing (CSCW Companion '24)*, November 9–13, 2024, San Jose, Costa Rica. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 3 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3678884.3687144>

1 THE IMPORTANCE OF GAMES AND PLAY RESEARCH AT CSCW

McLuhan proposes that games are “extensions of the popular response to the workaday stress” and “become faithful models of a culture” [15]. He also posits that “[g]ames are situations contrived to permit simultaneous participation of many people in some significant pattern of their own corporate lives” [15]. In this sense, games are always tied to broader social phenomena in people's lives and human societies. In the digital age, online gaming has become an even more popular recreational activity not only for the younger generation but also for older adults in different countries. For example, playing games on computers, consoles, or mobile devices (i.e., playing digital games) is a leading leisure activity, with consumers spending almost US \$190 billion on gaming in 2023 [18]. An estimated 79% of the global online population play videogames and Millennials, GenZ, and Gen Alpha spend more time engaging with games and virtual worlds than they do watching TV [18]. Players also engage casually, competitively, and even professionally through esports leagues and tournaments [5]. As such, the social and collaborative side of games and play has given rise to many questions about the social dynamics of digital games and their impacts on groups, teams, communities, and societies, which are highly valuable and relevant to the CSCW community.

Indeed, in the history of CSCW, digital games have been understood as specific applications of collaborative technology [2], social worlds that are different from other types of online social spaces [3, 4, 14], and virtual places to foster close friendships as well as both instrumental and social teams through collaborative and competitive play [8, 10, 17]. Generally, online games are a unique and valuable context for social computing research, as they are inherently social, having the potential for social benefits like social capital, relatedness, and wellbeing but also problematic and disruptive behaviors such as toxicity that harm those social benefits [9]. Beyond the social side of playing games, games and play research within CSCW



This work is licensed under a Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial International 4.0 License.

CSCW Companion '24, November 9–13, 2024, San Jose, Costa Rica
© 2024 Copyright held by the owner/author(s).
ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-1114-5/24/11
<https://doi.org/10.1145/3678884.3687144>

also contributes to understanding the social and collaborative nature of game design and development, such as how virtual game jams become emerging sites where non-professional game developers, amateurs, and hobbyists collaboratively design and develop more creative and novel digital products [7] and how indie game developers leverage various online platforms (e.g., live streaming) to innovate the traditional game production model [6, 11]. Additionally, there has been a growing trend to use games and play as a nuanced context to investigate other key CSCW topics, including but not limited to: using esports teams to understand human-AI collaboration [20] and team cognition [16], using gameplay to inform new interaction modality designs and novel interfaces [19], and using gaming live streaming to understand online privacy and spectator communities [12].

In summary, a core research agenda in CSCW is to explore how people work, live, and interact in various forms of collective lives such as groups, organizations, and communities [1]. Therefore, insights from studying games and play, which often reflect various social dynamics ranging from presence, communication, collaboration, conflict and competition, to community, well align with CSCW's focus and may also lead to broader impacts beyond CSCW research. For example, CSCW-related research in games and play can inform policy makers, who are concerned with topics such as screen addiction, child wellbeing, content rating systems, and the influence of games on learning in schools. Within CSCW, there are numerous points of connection between the games and play community and the broader CSCW landscape, with many researchers contributing equally to both contexts. Built upon our successful games and play SIG at CHI 2024 [13], it is these connections between games research and CSCW that we hope to identify and strengthen through this SIG.

2 GOALS OF THE SIG

Reflecting on the history and current context of the games and play research at CSCW, we recognize the diverse groups of researchers, students, academics, practitioners, and developers who contribute to introducing and promoting games and play research at CSCW, such as through studying gameplay, games as online communities, understanding and moderating the gaming community, game design/development experiences from a CSCW lens, or leveraging games and play as a valuable context to study other core CSCW concepts/questions. However, despite the shared research interests in games and play, we understand that these groups of researchers may often lack a dedicated opportunity to get together at CSCW to connect, network, and learn from each other's various research efforts and perspectives. We also recognize that there are currently many members of the larger CSCW community whose research and practice intersects with games and play. These members may never have attended a games-specific conference, and the purpose of this SIG is to offer a lightweight opportunity for CSCW attendees to connect with the games and play research community. Our aim is not only to meet as a community but also to reach out to and connect with CSCW researchers who have not traditionally seen their work as part of games and play for networking, inspiration, brainstorming, mutual learning, and idea exchange.

Together, we aim to:

- Gather the community of games and play academics, practitioners, and industry professionals together with CSCW researchers who intersect with topics related to games and play.
- Identify directions for a shared research agenda and potential research collaborations to address key topics presented below.
- Strengthen ties between games and play research and other areas of research within CSCW.
- Explore how games and play research and other areas of research within CSCW can benefit from each other.
- Build the interactive games community and a structured networking opportunity to CSCW researchers new to the games and play field.

3 TOPICS OF THE SIG

As mentioned above, the main goal of this SIG is to help both games and play researchers at CSCW and CSCW researchers who are interested in knowing more about games and play research connect with each other and further build a sense of community. We currently see interesting intersections with a range of CSCW topics, but would like to use the SIG to better articulate and communicate these intersections to the broader CSCW community. We have a number of open questions that we plan to address, such as:

- In which ways can games and play research inform and benefit the broader CSCW research context, and vice versa?
- How to better frame and situate games and play research within the broader CSCW research context?
- What are the opportunities and challenges of conducting games and play research through a CSCW perspective?
- What are the opportunities and challenges of exploring CSCW research topics in the context of games and play?
- What are some promising methods and approaches to help CSCW and games researchers better collaborate with each other?
- What theories prevalent in games and play versus CSCW research might help understand and interpret how people work, live, and interact in various forms of collective lives such as groups, organizations, and communities [1]?
- As games and play research is well known for studying new and emerging collaborative technologies and online behaviors (e.g., AI in games, VR/AR/XR games, moderating gaming communities), what might be the future trajectory of games and play research in the broader CSCW community?

4 ACTIVITIES AT THE SIG

We will organize and present the SIG in an interactive format. The SIG format will alternate between the SIG organizers posing questions to the audience and taking questions from the audience to gather community opinions. Rather than having organizers give their opinion on every topic, the organizers will facilitate a lively discussion by leaning into differing perspectives from smaller groups of attendees on the various topics that this SIG aims to explore. Through small group discussions, we will also help CSCW attendees and games researchers who share similar research interests connect with each other.

Below we outline an informal schedule for the 75-minute SIG.

- Welcome and introducing SIG organizers; an overview of the SIG and goals (10 minutes)
- Introduce open questions that we plan to address in this SIG; and elicit additional questions from the audience (10 minutes)
- Divide the audience into smaller groups based on the question they would like to discuss together; smaller group discussion (40 minutes)
- Each group reports back; closing remarks (15 minutes)

5 PLANS TO ATTRACT ATTENDEES

Prior to CSCW 2024, we will widely publicize and promote this SIG in games research community, CSCW community, and the broader HCI community through various social media channels (e.g., Facebook, X, and LinkedIn). We will especially focus on including participants who represent diverse backgrounds and reach out to our connections in communities that work with specific populations of underrepresented individuals. We will also reach out via mailing lists and other communities on Slack and Discord, not only associated with communities and universities in North America and Europe, but also via global networks especially in the global south.

6 ORGANIZER BIOS

Our organizers represent multiple academic backgrounds, domains of research and practice, and methodological approaches, bringing a diversity of perspectives to the organizing team.

Guo Freeman is an Associate Professor of Human-Centered Computing at Clemson University, USA. Her work focuses on how interactive technologies such as multiplayer online games, esports, live streaming, and social VR shape interpersonal relationships and group behavior; and how to design safe, inclusive, and supportive social VR spaces to combat emergent harassment risks especially for marginalized users.

Regan Mandryk is a Professor of Computer Science at the University of Victoria, Canada. Her work focuses on how people of all ages use games and playful technologies for social, cognitive, and emotional wellbeing, how toxicity, discrimination, and harassment thwart the connection and recovery benefits provided by multiplayer games, and how we can design games and play technologies that benefit—not harm—player wellbeing.

Julian Frommel is an Assistant Professor in Interaction/Multimedia at Utrecht University, the Netherlands. His work focuses on the design and implementation of interactive digital systems that provide enjoyable, meaningful, safe, and healthy experiences for users, including research on benefits and harms of video games such as the effects of toxicity and harassment in online games.

Pejman Mirza-Babaei is a Professor of HCI and Games at Ontario Tech University, Canada. His research and teaching is focused on the design and evaluation of user experience in interactive entertainment systems. He is a co-editor of the Games User Research (2018) book and a co-author of The Game Designer's Playbook: An Introduction to Game Interaction Design (2022).

Cliff Lampe is a Professor and Associate Dean for Academic Affairs at the University of Michigan School of Information, USA.

He also serves as Chair of the CHI Steering Committee and is a member of the CHI Academy. His work has highlighted moderation in online spaces, the effects of harassment and disinformation in online spaces, and recently the motivations behind harassers in these spaces.

REFERENCES

- [1] Mark S Ackerman. 2000. The intellectual challenge of CSCW: The gap between social requirements and technical feasibility. *Human-Computer Interaction* 15, 2-3 (2000), 179–203.
- [2] Barry Brown and Marek Bell. 2004. CSCW at play: 'there's a collaborative virtual environment. In *Proceedings of the 2004 ACM conference on Computer supported cooperative work*. 350–359.
- [3] Nicolas Ducheneaut and Robert J Moore. 2004. The social side of gaming: a study of interaction patterns in a massively multiplayer online game. In *Proceedings of the 2004 ACM conference on Computer supported cooperative work*. 360–369.
- [4] Nicolas Ducheneaut, Robert J Moore, and Eric Nickell. 2007. Virtual "third places": A case study of sociability in massively multiplayer games. *Computer Supported Cooperative Work (CSCW)* 16 (2007), 129–166.
- [5] Jessica Formosa, Nicholas O'donnell, Ella M Horton, Selen Türkay, Regan L Mandryk, Michael Hawks, and Daniel Johnson. 2022. Definitions of Esports: A Systematic Review and Thematic Analysis. *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction* 6, CHI PLAY (2022), 1–45.
- [6] Guo Freeman, Jeffrey Bardzell, Shaowen Bardzell, and Nathan McNeese. 2020. Mitigating Exploitation: Indie Game Developers' Reconfigurations of Labor in Technology. *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction* 4, CSCW1 (2020), 1–23.
- [7] Guo Freeman and Nathan J McNeese. 2021. A Tale of Creativity and Struggles: Team Practices for Bottom-Up Innovation in Virtual Game Jams. *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction* 5, CSCW1 (2021), 1–27.
- [8] Guo Freeman and Donghee Yvette Wohn. 2019. Understanding eSports team formation and coordination. *Computer supported cooperative work (CSCW)* 28 (2019), 95–126.
- [9] Julian Frommel, Daniel Johnson, and Regan L Mandryk. 2023. How perceived toxicity of gaming communities is associated with social capital, satisfaction of relatedness, and loneliness. *Computers in Human Behavior Reports* 10 (2023), 100302.
- [10] Yun Huang, Wenyue Ye, Nicholas Bennett, and Noshir Contractor. 2013. Functional or social? Exploring teams in online games. In *Proceedings of the 2013 conference on Computer supported cooperative work*. 399–408.
- [11] Lingyuan Li, Guo Freeman, and Nathan J McNeese. 2022. Channeling End-User Creativity: Leveraging Live Streaming for Distributed Collaboration in Indie Game Development. *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction* 6, CSCW2 (2022), 1–28.
- [12] Yao Li, Yubo Kou, Je Seok Lee, and Alfred Kobsa. 2018. Tell me before you stream me: Managing information disclosure in video game live streaming. *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction* 2, CSCW (2018), 1–18.
- [13] Regan L Mandryk, Pejman Mirza-Babaei, Alena Denisova, Guo Freeman, and Daniel Johnson. 2024. Games and Play SIG: Connecting Games Research to the Broader HCI Context. In *Extended Abstracts of the CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*. 1–6.
- [14] Gregor McEwan, Carl Gutwin, Regan L Mandryk, and Lennart Nacke. 2012. "I'm just here to play games" social dynamics and sociality in an online game site. In *Proceedings of the ACM 2012 conference on Computer Supported Cooperative Work*. 549–558.
- [15] Marshall McLuhan. 1994. *Understanding media: The extensions of man*. MIT press.
- [16] Geoff Musick, Rui Zhang, Nathan J McNeese, Guo Freeman, and Anurata Prabha Hridi. 2021. Leveling up teamwork in esports: Understanding team cognition in a dynamic virtual environment. *Proceedings of the ACM on human-computer interaction* 5, CSCW1 (2021), 1–30.
- [17] Bonnie Nardi and Justin Harris. 2006. Strangers and friends: Collaborative play in World of Warcraft. In *Proceedings of the 2006 20th anniversary conference on Computer supported cooperative work*. 149–158.
- [18] Newzoo. 2023. Global Gamer Study Report. newzoo.com
- [19] Paden Shorey and Audrey Girouard. 2017. Bendtroller: An exploration of in-game action mappings with a deformable game controller. In *Proceedings of the 2017 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*. 1447–1458.
- [20] Rui Zhang, Nathan J McNeese, Guo Freeman, and Geoff Musick. 2021. "An ideal human" expectations of AI teammates in human-AI teaming. *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction* 4, CSCW3 (2021), 1–25.